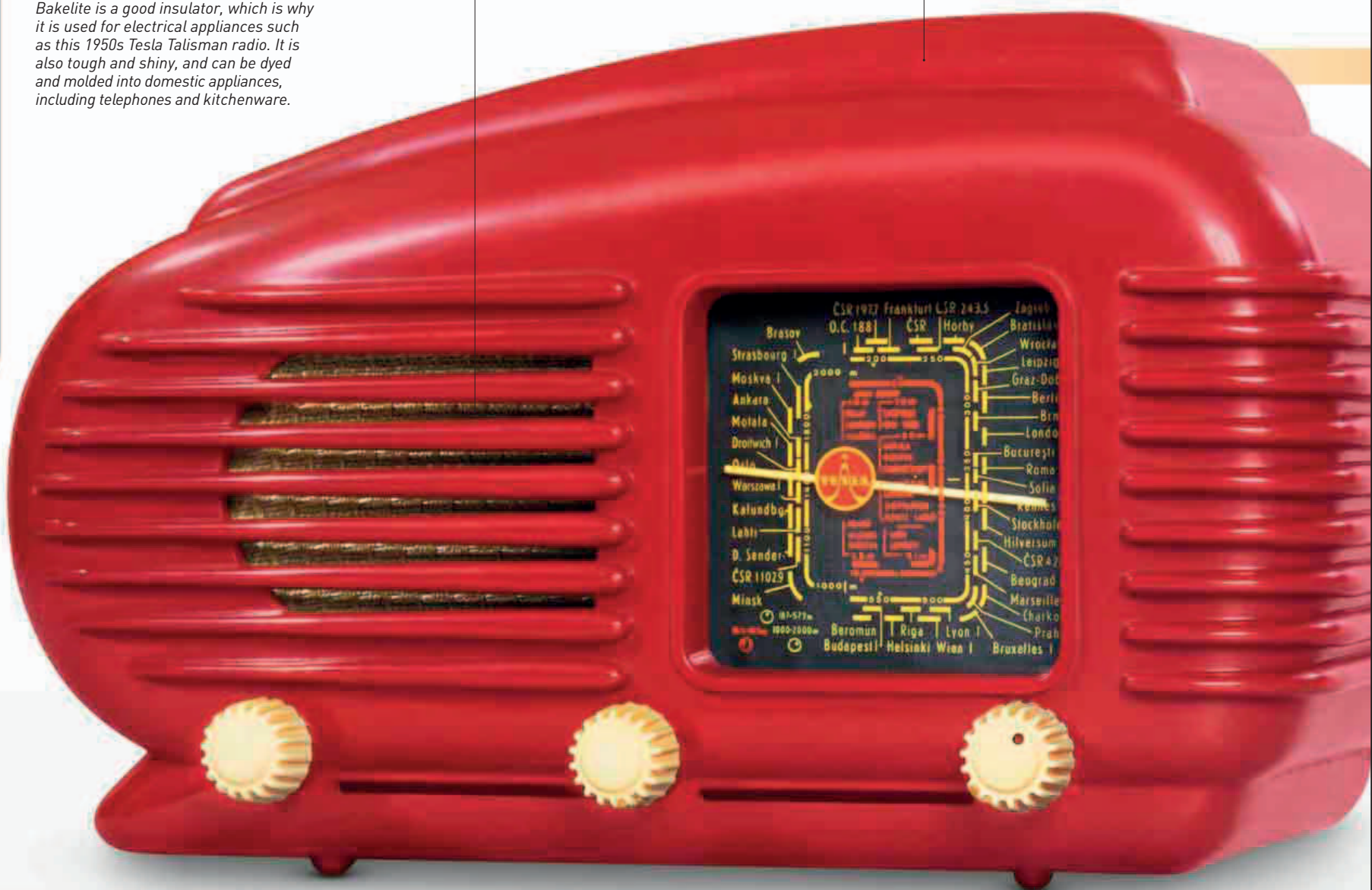


Bakelite radio

Bakelite is a good insulator, which is why it is used for electrical appliances such as this 1950s Tesla Talisman radio. It is also tough and shiny, and can be dyed and molded into domestic appliances, including telephones and kitchenware.

single loudspeaker

hard molded
bakelite shell**1862****Parkesine**

Alexander Parkes develops the first plastic—parkesine. It is used to make the first cheap buttons.

Parkesine
buttons**1887****Celluloid**

American John Hyatt and Englishman Daniel Spill both develop a material called celluloid that is similar to parkesine. It is used to make flexible film for photographs to replace glass plates. This is a crucial step for movie-making.



Celluloid film

1909**Bakelite**

American chemist Leo Baekeland first develops bakelite by treating phenol resin made from coal tar with formaldehyde. It is the first entirely synthetic plastic. Not only can it be molded, like earlier plastics, but once it sets it is hard and heatproof.

1872**PVC**

This extremely tough plastic is first developed in 1872 by German chemist Eugen Baumann. It is thought to be useless until the 1920s.



Golf ball

Viscose
fibers**1894****Viscose rayon**

Two English chemists produce a synthetic material called viscose (rayon) by reconstituting wood fibers in sodium hydroxide and spinning them into thread.



Sweet wrappers

1912**Cellophane**

Cellophane, a thin, transparent sheet made of processed cellulose, is first developed. It provides an airtight wrapping and is useful for packaging food.